circumstances, in which information and perception were clouded by the fog of war (if not, indeed, the radioactive fog of war).

The former British Defence Secretary and wartime veteran Denis Healey reflected in his autobiography: ‘My personal experience of war had taught me that battles never go as expected, and that the most rational man can behave irrationally once the bombs start falling.’[100] Once the nuclear bombs started falling, getting the retaliation in first or delivering a blow from the grave would have reflected a primordial yearning for vengeance on a scale surpassing all the wars and all the acts of evil in human history put together.[101]

The Cuban missile crisis did not end in nuclear war. But it might well have done. Some would say, it very nearly did. Few would question McGeorge Bundy’s entreaty not to pass this way again. The path that humanity did take after the crisis, what lessons were learned from the events of October 1962, and what lessons might now be learned from the events of October 1962, is the subject of chapter eight.